

referrer field as a reliable source of data for where the traffic to your site is coming from would therefore be a mistake.

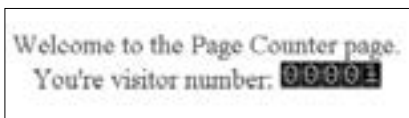
5. Counter Discounter

Using the primitive page counter system has its own problems.

This is usually a dynamic bit included in a Web page that increments a counter that is displayed each time a page is requested. This is usually a part of the Web site as a different “image” file, which is loaded every time you access the page.



A hit counter could look something like this...



....or like this

However, if the user has turned off the image display option in his browser, the images would not be displayed at all, leading to one count less in the counter. If a user just reloads a page, the counter registers another page view, not figuring that it's the same user viewing the same page again.

6. Spooky Cookies

Cookies may get into your system, but if you change the settings in your browser to block all Web sites from installing cookies on your computer, a Web site would be unable to identify you as an earlier user, and log you as a new one.

7. Tousled Browsers

The log, on a server, could also contain a “browser field” (also called the “User Agent” identifier), which is usually a piece of text that specifies what software was used to access the site. This, however, can be faked; Opera 8, for example, could fake being Internet Explorer to open MSN Web sites and other related Web pages which deliberately set up different styles that would not be compatible with non-IE browsers.

2.2.5 To Sum It Up